Well

By Lisa Kron

NOTE: This cutting asks one student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

NOTE: ***Actress 1: Lisa*** ***Actress 2: Ann, Oscar, Lori***

LISA: *(To the audience)* This play that we're about to do deals with issues of illness and wellness. It asks the question: Why are some people sick and other people are well? What is the difference between those people? This play is NOT about my mother and me. That is my mother. She doesn't feel well enough to get up and do things – but this is not about her. It's not about how she's been sick for years and years and years and I was sick -- but somehow I got better. It's not about how she was able to heal a neighborhood but she's not able to heal herself.

ANN: *(Groaning)* Oh, dear lord.

LISA: *(Reacting in sudden irritation to her mother's unexpected interruption)* Mom!!!

INTRODUCTION

TOGETHER: *Well by Lisa Kron*

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LISA: Mom, how're you doing?

ANN: *(NOTE: throughout the play, Ann should play up how bad she feels)* Oh, lord. I'm having such a bad allergy day. I just can't focus on anything. Of course I didn't get any sleep today because the phone started to ring at about ten o'clock this morning and people kept calling all through my

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prime sleeping hours so . . . *(To audience)* Oh, hello. Lisa, why don't you offer these people something to drink? *(painfully limping)* Oh, lord, this hip is just . . . . Oh! I don't know . . . *(exits)*

LISA: *(Watches her exit, then to the audience)* My mother's been sick, like that, for as long as I can remember. For her whole life actually. Well, I come from a family where everyone is ill. It is the norm . . . the family mystery illness – the general inability to move, to physically cope, to stay awake. This is the primary malady suffered by my mother.

ANN: *(enters with individual packages of chips and/or cookies and unexpected energy and impishness)* I found these at that restaurant supply place. Aren't they cute? Here. (*She throws one at Lisa. It hits her and falls. Ann is delighted)* You don't want one? They're so cute. *(She throws another one and hits Lisa again).* Okay. Suit yourself. *(She exits again toward the kitchen)*

LISA: *(To the audience)* My mother is a fantastically energetic person trapped in an utterly exhausted body. It's very confusing. Her energy level has two settings: all or nothing. Most of the time it's nothing, but when she has a burst of energy it's awe-inspiring. . For instance, when we were very young she decided she wanted my brother and me to be raised in a racially integrated neighborhood, and then she set about to create one.

ANN: *(returning, with a thought just occurring to her)* You're not writing a play about me are you? *(To audience)* I don't even like to have my picture taken. I certainly don't want to be in a play. *(Shrugging her shoulders . . . To Lisa)* [Well,] it's not like you're going to make it seem like I'm a hypochondriac or something. You go ahead and do your thing.

LISA: *(To audience)* From the time I was seven to the time I was fourteen, my

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mother was the president of the West Side Neighborhood Association. In 1968, when my mother started the Association, our neighborhood in Lansing, Michigan, was in serious trouble. She started suggesting to people that not only was the West Side not sick, but that an integrated neighborhood was actually healthier than a non-integrated neighborhood. The houses in this neighborhood are beautiful. The streets are curvy. There are flowers on the boulevards. When the first black families moved in, the city sent crews to dig the flowers up. That's the way it works, my mom says. That is how a slum is made. It's not that the people who live in the neighborhood aren't taking care of themselves. The city withdraws all the resources.

ANN: What else do you remember about that time?

LISA: *(entering a memory scene -- to the audience)* My best [friend was] Oscar. The neighborhood is integrated, but by demographic chance my brother and I are the only white kids in our school. In any case, it's a good thing to be different, my mother says. But I'm not so different from Oscar.

OSCAR: Hold up. I gotta idea. I gotta idea. Lisa. You stand here, I'm'a stand there. This is a really good game. It goes like this. I call out like this: "Hey, white girl!" And you call me back, "Hey, black boy!" Okay? It's cool. It's a cool game.

LISA: Okay, you start.

OSCAR: Hey, white girl!

LISA: Hey, black boy! *(They both laugh) (To the audience)* We continue in our loud, cool voices until I hear my mother call me. I go into the back hall where I am informed gently . . . but firmly that "black boy" is a phrase I am not to

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use again. I state the obvious: "But he is a black boy!" "Yes," she tells me . . .

LISA and ANNE: But that is a term that has been used historically to insult black men and it's hurtful . . . "

ANN: *(To the audience)* I don't have the vaguest recollection of saying that . . .

LISA: *(simultaneously with Ann above)* "Oscar's not hurt by it! He made up the game!" *(by herself)* Mom, please!

ANN: *(To Lisa)* Oh. Shh. I'm sorry

LISA: Mom . . . I'm doing a thing here. This is where we look more closely at your use of social activities to build the political power of the Association.

ANN: Oh, yeah. Everybody thought I was kooky about that, just like they think I'm kooky about the allergies now. Nobody could figure out why I'd put so much work into a Fourth of July celebration. *(makes a horrible noise of pain)* Oy, boy, Oy, boy.

LISA: *(To Ann)* Are you all right?

ANN: Yeah. I'm about to take a pain pill *(Reaches for her glass, even more pain)* Oh! If I could reach that glass of water. It's just a little out of my reach unless I get up out of this chair, which I would rather not do right now. *(switches character to LORI)*

LORI: Lisa!

LISA: What do you want?!

LORI: What do you have to do with your hair? *(Pokes Lisa in the head)* *(Pulling at Lisa's hair)* Ugly, stringy, nasty. Eew.

LISA: *(Doing her best to be firm)* Okay. I'm going to have to ask you to leave –

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LORI: You're gonna what? *(A threatening pause)* You're gonna what? *(Lisa is trapped in Lori's treacherous gaze for a moment, until suddenly Lori makes a move and chases Lisa across the stage into Ann's area – LORI morphs back into ANNE)*

ANN: What's going on?

LISA: I don't know! I'm being tormented by a nine year old from my past, who is creating a totally wrong impression about the neighborhood. *(To the audience)* What I am trying to convey is that the Association stabilized the neighborhood and, by the way, it's still a stable racially integrated neighborhood today. Okay, there might have been a little bit of tension between some of the kids. But the big picture is that the Neighborhood Association was working. The adults were getting along.

ANN: What are you talking about? Of course there was tension among the adults. You're right, the Association was very successful –

LISA: Yes!

ANN: . . . but there were certainly tensions. Howard and Jim for instance, those two were condescending as all get out. You know, they took over.

LISA: *(Muttering to herself)* Okay, go ahead. Tell the story.

ANN: Oh, yeah. At the end of the second year, when it was suddenly clear that the Association had become a major political power in the city of Lansing, Jim ran against me for president because, as he said: "Now that the Association has gotten some power it's time for a man to take over." When Jim took over, they went ahead and cut all the things that they thought were so frivolous – the door-to-door newsletter delivery and the holiday decorations and all of that – and at the end of the year all the power was gone and no one was even showing up for meetings . . . I sure

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didn't like how condescending they were, but frankly I was relieved that someone else was finally willing to take over. I hadn't been well enough to do it in the first place. *(ANNE morphs into Lori Jones enters, looks at Lisa and bursts into loud, derisive laughter)*

LISA: *(To audience)* Okay, I would like to make something clear here. I would like you to know that Lori Jones is NOT representative of my experience growing up in this neighborhood. *(Lori moves in on Lisa and runs her finger up Lisa's back.)*

LORI: *(Overlapping)* How come you ain't got no bra on yet?

LISA: *(Overlapping)* – it does not make clear that growing up –

LORI: *(Overlapping)* Hmm? How come you don't answer me?

LISA: *(Overlapping)* - growing up in this neighborhood was a positive –

LORI: *(Overlapping)* Are you deaf?

LISA: *(Overlapping)* - it was a positive experience, but Lori J –

LORI: *(Overlapping)* I said: "Are You Deaf?" Huh? Huh? Huh?

LISA: *(Overlapping)* -- Lori Jones is not helping to establish that. Seeing her is just going to play into any stereotypes you might already be holding.

LORI: *(To Lisa)* I don't care if you don't want me in your stupid play. What're you going to do about it? 'Cause I was in your stupid life. *(exits)*

LISA: *(To Ann)* Do you see why I don't want her in my . . .

ANN: Well, yes and no. Bad manners is one thig. Kick Lori out of the play for acting like a crumb if you want, but not because she's not an appropriate "representation." Part of the point of growing up in an integrated neighborhood was that you didn't have to extrapolate from abstract impressions of black people, because you knew actual people. Lori didn't

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have that kind of power. She was just one little girl. *(BEAT)*

LISA: YOU KNOW WHAT? WHY DON'T YOU DO YOUR OWN SHOW? YOU TELL THEM THE "REAL STORY," SINCE APPARENTLY I'M NOT DOING IT RIGHT. HAVE A REALLY FUN TIME, MOM, BECAUSE IT'S YOUR SHOW! *(Exits)*

ANN: I don't want a show. *(To the audience)* She must be having a reaction. *(Pause) (To Lisa)* Lisa? Your audience is still here, honey. *(Back to the audience)* I don't know where I got my ideas about integration and so forth, because the town where I grew up was all white, so it's not like I had any personal experiences with it. I had very strong feelings about the evils of segregation and the evils of discrimination and all that. Lisa . . . she is like an amazing star to me – my daughter. We were rooted in the same place, and she kept growing which was the most wonderful thing. To see her branch off and to have a life so different, and to have all that energy that I couldn't even imagine. But I guess I never questioned that we were starting from the same place. But I think maybe she doesn't feel that. *(Ann waits for a response from Lisa. There is none. She retreats into her private thoughts and then transitions into an emotionally exhausted half-sleeping state)*

LISA: *(To audience)* Sometimes I see her in that almost comatose state – even just to raise her arm a little or turn her head makes her gasp in pain, and I get angry. She can't walk. She can't move. The moaning – the moaning drives me CRAZY. What is the difference between that body and mine? I look at her in that state and I feel like I'm going to drown! *(Beat, deep cleansing breath) (To Ann)* Hey.

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ANN: Do you want to just say whatever it is you're afraid to say to me? Because I'll tell you, frankly, I'd rather you just said it out loud whatever it is.

LISA: *(To audience)* What am I supposed to say to her?! . . . I moved to New York and got into therapy. I learned, finally what I never learned at home, that there is a correlation between not sleeping at night and feeling tired during the day. I started to learn how to inhabit my body – that there is an alternative to dragging your body around like a stone and wishing it would disappear. That the label of "allergies" doesn't work for me. That I resent that the sick people keep trying to pull me down and make me like them. I escaped to the land of the healthy people – and when I come back here I want to scream: "I AM NOT LIKE YOU!" And then I'm seized with dread because how do I know, really, that I'm not.

ANN: Oh! Lisa, did you really bring me out here to make people think that I'm crazy and . . . whiney . . . and a hypochondriac? I'm about ready to come over there and wring your neck if you don't just say what you have to say to me.

LISA: *(Overlapping)* I can't. This thing has gotten all out of proportion.

ANN: *(Overlapping)* You can –

LISA: *(Overlapping)* I can't. .There's nothing –

ANN: *(Overlapping)* You're tying yourself in knots – just say what you want to say.

LISA: How can you let this happen?! WHY CAN'T YOU MAKE YOURSELF WELL?! *(Tiny stunned pause)*

ANN: That is a horrible question. You have seen me struggle for years.

LISA: I was sick, too. And I got better.

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ANN: And I am so grateful for that. But we are not the same person

LISA: But, we were, Mom. We were. I wanted to be just like you. I thought I was going to save a neighborhood because I couldn't imagine a life more meaningful than that. But in order to get better, I had to grow in a different direction. I left home and I got better.

ANN: So what you're saying is – what? How do you think you got better?

LISA: I think I was sick because you were sick, Mom. I think I watched you and took for granted that it was how one lives in the world. And then I went away and learned I didn't have to be that way. Why are some people sick and other people get well? *(To audience)* She's overwhelming to me. She doesn't make any sense. She's so sick. And she's so well. I can't make her make sense . . . . This is something my mother wrote for one of the [Association] meetings:

(She reads as Ann gives voice to the letter; voices can overlap and ANNE's voice should gain strength, her stature should become stronger – she should become "well" during this closing)

ANN: This organization is about people. It's about busy people and lonely people. Happy people and frightened people. Young people who want a good life for their children, and old people who want to know that somebody cares. People so busy that they don't have time to wonder if anything they are doing is worthwhile, and people who face day after day of having nothing to do but wish that someone might need them. This is what integration means. It means weaving into the whole even the parts that are uncomfortable or don't seem to fit. Even the parts that are complicated and painful. What is more worthy of our time and our love than this.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Lisa Kron
ISBN: 978-1559362535
Publisher: Theatre Communications Group
Date (Month/Year): March 2006

AWARD HISTORY

IL State Qualifier

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